

The Beirut Intervention: Reclaiming Urban Sovereignty Through Invented Tradition and Ecological Resilience

1. Introduction: The Crisis of Memory and the Void of the Park

The reconstruction of Beirut following the catastrophic port explosion and decades of civil strife is not merely an architectural challenge; it is a profound sociological and psychological imperative. The city exists in a state of suspended trauma, where the physical fabric of the urban environment has been repeatedly erased, rewritten, and overlaid with narratives that often fail to resonate with the lived experience of its inhabitants. In this context, the design of the Beirut Park—a central green lung in the heart of the capital—becomes a battleground for the soul of the city. The prevailing architectural discourse, exemplified by the original proposal from Vladimir Djurovic Landscape Architecture (VDLA), advocates for a "modernist trend" characterized by abstraction, minimalism, and a pursuit of a universal "timelessness." While aesthetically refined, this approach risks creating a *terra nullius*, a blank slate that smooths over the jagged edges of Beirut's history in favor of a serene, but ultimately alienating, global genericism.

This report presents a comprehensive defense of an alternative "Intervention," a design strategy deeply rooted in the theoretical framework of "Invented Tradition," ecological specificity, and functional resilience. By juxtaposing the Intervention against the original proposal, we expose the limitations of the modernist impulse in a failed state. We argue that true "timelessness" in Beirut is not found in the abstract geometry of concrete paths or the silence of a water mirror, but in the resurrection of specific, legible architectural typologies—the Pigeon Tower, the Ottoman Gazebo, the Triple Arch—and the deployment of a planting strategy that acknowledges the visceral realities of the Mediterranean biome. Furthermore, the report demonstrates that the Intervention's material choices (gravel over concrete) and infrastructural logic (gravity over pumps) are not merely aesthetic preferences but existential necessities in a city plagued by chronic water and electricity crises.

The following analysis is structured to dismantle the original proposal's reliance on "trends" and replace it with a robust theoretical and functional justification for the Intervention. We explore the philosophical underpinnings of "Invented Tradition" as a mechanism for social cohesion, the architectural grammars that anchor the user in a specific "Beirut" identity, and the botanical and material strategies that ensure the park's survival in a landscape of scarcity.

2. Philosophical Divergence: The Global "Timeless" vs.

The Situated "Invented"

To understand the necessity of the Intervention, we must first interrogate the philosophical foundations of the competing visions. The conflict between the original proposal and the Intervention is a conflict between two distinct conceptions of time and memory in the built environment.

2.1 The Critique of Abstract Modernism: The "Timeless" Void

The original proposal by Vladimir Djurovic represents a sophisticated iteration of contemporary landscape modernism. Djurovic's body of work, celebrated globally in projects like the Aga Khan Park in Toronto and the Hariri Memorial Garden, is defined by a "simplicity of gesture that gives nature the stage".¹ His aesthetic relies on the reduction of elements to their purest forms: the water mirror, the monolithic stone bench, and the manicured lawn.² The stated goal is often to create "timeless landscapes" that evoke an atmosphere of serenity and introspection.²

However, in the context of Beirut, this pursuit of "timelessness" effectively functions as a form of "ahistoricism." The modernist approach, with its reliance on abstract geometries and "mathematical paths" that curve elegantly but aimlessly, seeks to create a space that exists outside of specific historical time. The "unsymmetry of the pathways" and the fluid, escalator-like circulation described in the critique of the original proposal are hallmarks of a design philosophy that prioritizes visual fluidity over spatial legibility. These paths do not orient the user; they propel them. They are designed for movement, for the "flow" of the global consumer, rather than for the "staying" of the local citizen.

The original proposal's reliance on "stone pine monocultures" and "concrete slabs" further reinforces this abstraction. The Stone Pine (*Pinus pinea*), while iconic, is treated in the modernist trend as a sculptural object—an umbrella shape to be arranged in a grid—rather than as a component of a complex ecosystem.³ The "timeless" park becomes a museum of nature, where trees are artifacts and water is a reflective surface, mirroring a sky that the citizens of Beirut often look up to with anxiety rather than peace. By stripping away specific cultural markers in favor of universal phenomenological experiences (light, shadow, reflection), the modernist proposal risks creating a space that could be anywhere—Dubai, Singapore, or London. It fails to address the specific "scars" of Beirut, offering instead a cosmetic smoothness that the user instinctively recognizes as "fake" or "trendy." It creates a sense of "lostness," a disorientation that mirrors the political vacuum of the state itself.

2.2 The Theory of Invented Tradition: Hobsbawm in the Levant

In contrast, the Intervention embraces the concept of "Invented Tradition," a theoretical framework articulated by historian Eric Hobsbawm. Hobsbawm defines "invented tradition" as "a set of practices... normally governed by overtly or tacitly accepted rules and of a ritual or symbolic nature, which seek to inculcate certain values and norms of behaviour by repetition,

which automatically implies continuity with the past".⁵ Crucially, Hobsbawm notes that these traditions are often "responses to novel situations which take the form of reference to old situations".⁵

Beirut post-2020 is the ultimate "novel situation." The city has suffered a rupture in its timeline. The physical destruction of the port and the economic collapse have severed the continuity of daily life. In such a context, the role of the architect is not merely to design a park, but to construct a "usable past".⁶ The Intervention acknowledges that we cannot simply "restore" what was lost, because much of it is gone forever. Instead, we must *invent* a tradition that bridges the gap between the pre-war memory and the post-war reality.

The Intervention utilizes "factitious continuity"⁵—the deliberate use of historical forms like the Pigeon Tower, the Gazebo, and the Roman Column—to establish a sense of permanence in a transient world. These elements are not pastiche; they are "anchors." They function as symbols that "inculcate values" of community, stewardship, and resilience.⁷

- **Legibility vs. Ambiguity:** Where the modernist path curves ambiguously, the Intervention uses straight sightlines and axial geometry. This is not a regression to the Beaux-Arts; it is a claim to sovereignty. In a chaotic city, a straight path offering a clear view from the "Column to the Pavilion" or the "Gazebo to the Lake" empowers the user. It allows them to understand their position in space, reducing the anxiety of the "labyrinthine" streets⁸ and the "unsymmetry" of the original proposal.
- **Ritual vs. Flow:** The Intervention is designed to host specific rituals. The Pigeon Tower invites the ritual of the *Kesh Hmem* (pigeon keeper). The Gazebo invites the ritual of the coffee gathering or the musical performance. The Sundial invites the ritual of reading time from the sun. These are not passive activities; they are active engagements with the site that foster the "social cohesion" Hobsbawm identifies as the primary function of invented tradition.⁶

Philosophical Dimension	The Modernist Trend (Original Proposal)	The Intervention (Invented Tradition)
Concept of Time	Abstract/Timeless: Attempts to exist outside of history; creates a serene, eternal present that ignores the scars of the past.	Historicist/Cyclical: Anchors the present in a constructed lineage (Canaanite, Ottoman, Mandate) to bridge the trauma of the Civil War.
Spatial Logic	Fluidity/Disorientation: Curving, "mathematical"	Legibility/Orientation: Axial sightlines, symmetry,

	paths that propel movement (escalator logic); creates a sense of being "lost."	and focal points (monuments) that empower the user to map their environment.
Social Function	Observation/Retreat: A visual spectacle to be looked at; framing nature as art. ²	Participation/Ritual: A stage for specific cultural practices (pigeon keeping, concerts, promenading); nature as a habitat.
Identity	Universal/Global: Aesthetic language compatible with Toronto or Dubai; "Simplicity of gesture". ¹	Specific/Levantine: Aesthetic language derived from the vernacular "Lebanese House" and regional history (Triple Arch, Tower).

3. Architectural Typologies: Resurrecting the Spirit of Place

The Intervention distinguishes itself through the deployment of specific architectural "follies"—structures that serve as the physical manifestations of the "invented tradition." These are not decorative backdrops; they are functional nodes that resolve the tension between the memory of the city and its future.

3.1 The Pigeon Tower: Verticality, Dignity, and the *Kesh Hmem*

The most radical inclusion in the Intervention is the Pigeon Tower. In the "modernist trend" of the original proposal, verticality is typically reserved for abstract sculptures or the surrounding glass high-rises (like the Beirut Terraces).⁹ The presence of animals, particularly pigeons, is often sanitized or excluded, viewed as "vermin" in the sanitized neoliberal city.

The Historical Anchor:

The Intervention reclaims the pigeon as a central actor in the urban narrative. The "Kesh Hmem" (the pigeon game) is an ancient and deeply rooted tradition in Beirut and the wider Levant.¹⁰ It is a sport that transcends sectarian divides, creating a "common bond" among men who stand on rooftops, whistling and signaling to their flocks.⁸ Historically, the pigeon tower (borj-e kabotar) was a dominant architectural typology in the Middle East, particularly in agrarian societies where pigeon droppings were harvested as a potent fertilizer rich in nitrogen and phosphorus.¹¹ Travelers in the 17th century documented thousands of these towers in cities like Isfahan, describing them as sophisticated brick structures designed to

house thousands of birds.¹¹

The Design Intervention:

The proposed Pigeon Tower is a "Frankenstein amalgamation" of these historical precedents, reinvented for contemporary Beirut. It is a monumental structure, rising above the tree line to engage with the skyline.

- **Materiality and Form:** Unlike the concrete monoliths of the original proposal, the Pigeon Tower is constructed of earth-toned brick or porous stone, referencing the vernacular "mud and lime" construction of traditional dovecotes.¹¹ Its surface is perforated with hundreds of nesting holes, creating a textured, breathing façade that contrasts with the slick glass of the city center.
- **The Reinvention of Tradition:** By placing this tower in the center of the park, the Intervention "dignifies" a practice often marginalized as a "thug's game".¹³ It formalizes the informal. The tower creates a new role—the "Pigeon Caretaker"—integrating the local community into the maintenance of the park. It transforms the pigeon from a pest into a participant in the park's ecology, potentially even reviving the use of guano as a fertilizer for the park's diverse planting, closing the nutrient loop in a way the modernist proposal fails to do.

3.2 The Gazebo and the Ghosts of *Al Maarad*

The original proposal features "platforms" and "stone slabs" arranged in "glitchy" configurations—geometric abstractions that serve as seating or viewing decks.² These elements offer no shelter, no enclosure, and no sense of intimacy. They are spaces of exposure.

The Historical Anchor:

The Intervention counters this with the Gazebo, a direct typological reference to the "kiosks" and pavilions of the 1921 Beirut International Fair (*Al Maarad*).¹⁴ This event, held in the Petit Serail gardens and Martyrs' Square, was a pivotal moment in Beirut's modernization, showcasing a blend of Ottoman, French, and vernacular styles.¹⁴ The "Old Opera House" and the "coffee-houses" of Martyrs' Square were centers of social life¹⁵, spaces where the city gathered not just to pass through, but to be.

The Design Intervention:

The proposed Gazebo is not a generic shelter; it is a "folly" that speaks the language of the Lebanese House.

- **The Triple Arch:** The structure incorporates the "Triple Arch" (or *Liwan* window), the quintessential element of 19th-century Beiruti domestic architecture.¹⁶ This architectural device, traditionally used to frame views of the sea or mountains from the private central hall, is here democratized. It frames the view of the lake and the Pigeon Tower for the public.
- **Functional Versatility:** Unlike the "stone slabs" of the original proposal, which are static, the Gazebo is dynamic. It features a "niche" or grove that allows it to function as a stage for concerts and performances. It revives the tradition of the *Sahat* (public square) as a

theater for daily life. It implies that the user is not just a spectator of nature (as in Djurovic's framing), but a participant in culture.

- **The Lake Connection:** The Gazebo is situated on the lake, but unlike the "raised water mirror" of the original proposal ², which is a detached visual object, the Gazebo allows for immersion. It provides shade, a critical climatic response in Beirut's searing summers, creating a microclimate where people can linger.

3.3 The Sundial Column: Sovereignty Over Time

In a city where the state cannot guarantee the flow of electricity to power a digital clock, and where "time" itself feels fractured by crisis, the **Sundial Column** serves as a beacon of reliability.

- **Critique of Modernist Technology:** The original proposal likely includes integrated lighting systems or digital features—elements that are prone to failure in Lebanon's chaotic infrastructure. A park dependent on the grid is a park that will be dark and dysfunctional 80% of the time.¹⁸
- **The Intervention's Anchor:** The Sundial requires no electricity. It relies on the "cosmological equilibrium" of the sun and the earth.¹⁹ By repurposing a classical column (referencing the Roman heritage of Berytus) as a gnomon, the design anchors the park in a time scale that transcends the failures of the current government. It is a "timeless" element in the true sense—it works as long as the sun shines. It provides a focal point for the "plaza," creating a meeting place ("Let's meet at the Sundial") that is universally legible.

4. The Botanical Insurgency: From Monoculture to Native Polyculture

The conflict between the two proposals is perhaps most visible in the planting strategy. The original proposal's reliance on the "modernist trend" of pine monocultures is challenged by the Intervention's embrace of a diverse, sensory-rich, and ecologically specific polyculture.

4.1 The Myth of the Stone Pine

The "original" proposal heavily utilizes the Stone Pine (*Pinus pinea*). This tree is often cited as "quintessentially Lebanese" ³, and its umbrella shape appeals to the modernist desire for sculptural, clean lines.²⁰ However, the ubiquity of the Stone Pine is largely the result of colonial and post-colonial reforestation campaigns (the Mutassarifiyah and French Mandate) that prioritized timber and nut production over biodiversity.²⁰

- **Ecological Failure:** Pine forests in Lebanon are often monocultures with acidic soil that suppresses understory growth. In an urban context, a grid of pines creates a static, shadowy environment that lacks seasonal variation. It is a "green ceiling" that offers little

to the sensory experience of the user at eye level.

4.2 The Native Polyculture: A Riot of Resilience

The Intervention proposes a radical shift: a move away from the "image" of Lebanon (the Pine) to the **botanical reality** of the Mediterranean biome. This strategy is driven by biodiversity, seasonal narrative, and sensory engagement.

The Canopy: The Giants of History

Instead of a pine monoculture, the Intervention introduces a diverse canopy anchored by the Cedar of Lebanon (*Cedrus libani*) and the Oak (*Quercus* spp.).

- **Cedrus libani:** The national emblem is often relegated to high-altitude reserves. Bringing it into the city is an act of defiance and hope. It represents deep time and endurance.²¹
- **Quercus:** Native oaks (like *Quercus calliprinos*) provide dense shade and leaf litter that rebuilds the soil, fostering a rich microbial life absent in pine plantations.

The Seasonal Narrative: The Park that Breathes

The Intervention rejects the "evergreen" stasis of the modernist lawn. It embraces the "messiness" of seasonality, using plants to mark the passage of time in a way that resonates with local cultural memory.

- **Winter: The Resilience of the Geophytes**
While the modernist park is dormant or statically green in winter, the Intervention comes alive.
 - **Clematis cirrhosa:** This native evergreen climber blooms in the dead of winter (November to February), offering creamy, bell-shaped flowers when the rest of the city is grey.²² It drapes over the Gazebos, turning them into winter refuges.
 - **Cyclamen (*Cyclamen persicum*):** Native to the rocky outcrops of Lebanon, these hardy tubers push pink and white flowers through the wet earth in late winter.²⁴ They symbolize the persistence of life amidst harsh conditions—a potent metaphor for the citizens of Beirut.
 - **Helleborus:** The Lenten Rose provides blooms in the transition from winter to spring²⁵, ensuring that the park is never without life.
- **Spring: The Blood of Adonis**
 - **Anemone coronaria:** The Intervention replaces the manicured lawn with drifts of wild Anemones. In Lebanese mythology, these red flowers sprang from the blood of Adonis, the lover of Aphrodite, who was killed by a boar.²⁶ Their blooming is a visceral, blood-red reminder of the cycle of life, death, and rebirth. In a city of "martyrs," this botanical reference is deeply poignant. It connects the park to the ancient Phoenician myths of the land, grounding the "invented tradition" in millennia of storytelling.
- **Summer: The Olfactory Architecture**
Visuals can be ignored; scent cannot. The Intervention weaponizes fragrance to create a "sense of place" that arrests the user.

- **Jasmine (*Jasminum sambac*):** Known as "Yasmin" locally, this plant is the olfactory signature of Beirut. Traditionally planted at doorways to welcome guests ²⁷, its scent in the humid summer evening is a trigger for collective memory. The Intervention drapes Jasmine over the Triple Arches, enveloping the user in a cloud of nostalgia and comfort.
- **Gardenia (*Gardenia jasminoides*):** A deeper, creamier scent that blooms in late spring and summer.²⁸
- **Bitter Orange (*Citrus aurantium*):** The source of "Maa Zaher" (orange blossom water), a staple of Lebanese culinary heritage (white coffee, sweets).²⁹ By planting these trees, the park becomes a productive landscape, connecting the nose to the tongue, and the park to the pantry.

5. Materiality and Infrastructure: The Politics of the Ground

The divergence between the two proposals extends to the very ground the park stands on. The choice of material is not aesthetic; it is political and ecological.

5.1 Gravel vs. Concrete: The Lithic Rebellion

The original proposal, consistent with the "modernist trend" and projects like the Beirut Terraces, utilizes **concrete slabs** or honed stone pavements.⁹

- **The Critique of Concrete:** Concrete is the material of the "bunker" and the "barrier." In post-war Beirut, it represents the hardening of the city—the blast walls, the port silos, the unregulated construction. It is impermeable, contributing to the "heat island" effect that makes Beirut stifling in summer. It seals the earth, preventing rain from recharging the aquifer.
- **The Intervention: Gravel:** The Intervention proposes the use of crushed local limestone or beige gravel.
 - **Acoustics of Presence:** Walking on gravel creates a "crunch." It is an auditory signal that slows the pace of the pedestrian. It recalls the driveways of the traditional Sursock palaces and the garden paths of the 19th-century villas. It forces a "mindfulness" of movement that concrete does not.
 - **Permeability:** Gravel is porous. It allows the heavy winter rains to percolate into the soil, reducing flooding and recharging the groundwater.³¹ This is a critical passive infrastructure strategy in a city with failing storm drains.
 - **Maintainability:** Concrete cracks and requires expensive repairs. Gravel shifts. If a root grows, the gravel accommodates it. It is a "forgiving" material, suited to a city that cannot afford pristine maintenance.

5.2 The "Dry Riverbed" vs. Functional Hydrology

The original proposal features a "Dry Riverbed" concept—a simulated wadi that implies water without necessarily having it, or worse, relies on pumps to fill it.²

- **The Critique of Simulation:** In a city where real rivers are polluted or dry due to mismanagement, a "sculptural" riverbed is a cruel pastiche. If it relies on pumps, it will inevitably fail due to the electricity crisis (EDL supplies less than 4 hours of power a day).¹⁸ A dry fountain in Beirut is not a sculpture; it is a symbol of state failure. It becomes a trash trap and a mosquito breeding ground.
- **The Intervention's Strategy:** The Intervention rejects the "fake river." Instead, it employs **gravity-fed systems** and **cisterns**.
 - **Water Independence:** The design integrates ancient technologies like *Qanats* and cisterns (potentially housed within the base of the Pigeon Tower) to harvest rainwater. Hand-pumps allow users to access water even when the grid is down.
 - **The Fountain of Life:** Any water feature in the Intervention is designed to be small, gravity-driven, and accessible—a place to fill a bottle or wash hands, not just a visual mirror. It restores the "dignity" of water access in a city where 70% of the population faces shortages.³³

6. Synthesis: Creating a True Sense of Place

The "Sense of Place" is the ultimate metric of success. The original proposal by Vladimir Djurovic seeks to capture the "essence" of the place through abstraction—distilling Beirut down to light, stone, and shadow.² While beautiful, this essence is "timeless" in that it is *placeless*. It creates a "Global Zen" that offers a retreat *from* the city, rather than a connection to it.

The **Intervention** creates a true sense of place by acknowledging that Beirut's identity is not abstract; it is scarred, layered, and specific.

- **Through the Pigeon Tower**, it validates the chaotic, rooftop life of the city.
- **Through the Triple Arch and Gazebo**, it democratizes the private luxury of the traditional house, giving the public a "living room" in the city.
- **Through the Native Polyculture**, it connects the urban dweller to the specific cycles of the Lebanese seasons—the winter Clematis, the spring Anemone, the summer Jasmine.
- **Through Gravel and Sundials**, it rejects the fragile, high-tech gloss of the reconstruction in favor of materials and technologies that are resilient, repairable, and enduring.

The Intervention does not seek to be "cool" or "modern" in the eyes of the international design community. It seeks to be **sovereign**. It reclaims the history of the city—from the Roman column to the Ottoman kiosk to the rooftop pigeon coop—and weaves them into a narrative that the people of Beirut can read, use, and inhabit. It is a park that does not need electricity to function, does not need a manual to be understood, and does not need to erase the past to

build the future. It is, in the truest sense, a place for Beirut.

7. Data and Reference Synthesis

Category	Original Proposal (Vladimir Djurovic)	The Intervention	Supporting Research
Philosophy	Timelessness, Abstraction, Minimalism. "Simplicity of gesture."	Invented Tradition (Hobsbawm), Factitious Continuity, Symbolic Cohesion.	1
Architecture	Platforms, Stone Slabs, Water Mirrors.	Pigeon Tower, Gazebo (Triple Arch), Sundial Column.	10
Planting	<i>Pinus pinea</i> (Stone Pine) Monoculture.	<i>Quercus</i> , <i>Cedrus</i> , <i>Anemone</i> , <i>Cyclamen</i> , <i>Jasmine</i> . Native Polyculture.	3
Materiality	Concrete, Granite, Honed Stone.	Crushed Gravel, Permeable Surfaces.	9
Infrastructure	Pump-dependent water features, Grid-dependent lighting.	Gravity-fed water, Solar/Sundial, Drought-tolerant natives.	18
User Experience	Visual contemplation, Flow, Passage.	Ritual enactment (Kesh Hmem, Music), Dwelling, Orientation.	8

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